

FIELD GUIDE NO. 03 · COSTA RICA · 9°56′N 84°05′W · SINCE 1991

Costa Rica, *the Long Way Round*

A field guide to Costa Rica's wildlife, rainforest lodges and wild coasts, from an explorer who first came in 1991

JAMES WILD & CO. · LEDGERED & VETTED · JOURNEY DESIGN SINCE 1982

PREPARED FOR

Jane Traveler

TRAVELER FOLIO · JW-F-0001

COVER · THE PACIFIC COAST AT DUSK · GETTY IMAGES

A LETTER BEFORE YOU GO

Dear Jane,

I first came to Costa Rica in 1991 with a surfboard, a map that was mostly guesswork and a rental car that was mostly rust. After a few short jaunts to the Bahamas and selling my very first surf trip, this was where I branched out. We ran one of the first surf and adventure travel companies here, Adventure Expeditions, and spent the early nineties finding and mapping the breaks, up into Nicaragua and down into Panama. Later I worked as a wholesaler for many of the big travel brands, which is a polite way of saying I drove every bad road so their guests wouldn't have to.

We got stuck. A lot. We took the wrong turn so often it became the route. We drove into rivers and, more than once, never reached the other side. Small planes landed on dirt strips, and you checked the rafters before you sat down. It was raw, it was wild and it was very, very cheap.

Well, now. The roads are paved (mostly), the lodges are some of the finest in the Americas, and the price has caught up with the view. The forest, the animals and the people haven't changed a bit. That's why I keep going back.

This guide is page one of your Folio. Mark it up. Circle what makes you grin. Cross out what doesn't. When we talk, I'll already know which kind of traveler you are.

J. Wild CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER · COSTA RICA SINCE 1991

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

Then and now

	1991, when I first came	Today
VISITORS	About 504,000 international visitors	Nearly 2.95 million (2025)
THE WAY IN	Dirt roads, river fords and a few grass airstrips	Two international airports, San José and Liberia, and paved roads to most coasts
THE PRICE	Raw and very inexpensive	Well, now...

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How to read the marks

I KEEP GOING BACK *since 1991* — Places James has gone back to since 1991.

I KNOW A PLACE *I slept here* — James has stayed there himself.

I KNOW WHO KNOWS *partner vetted* — Vetted through a partner we trust.

I'LL KNOW SOON *well worth the visit* — On James's list. Recommended, honestly marked.

The colours of Costa Rica

Every James Wild & Co. guide wears the colours of its destination's terrain. This one is drawn from volcanic black sand, cloud forest, highland coffee and the Pacific.

BLACK SAND · CLOUD FOREST · COFFEE MOSS · PACIFIC TEAL · DEEP PACIFIC

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Two oceans, one long afternoon apart

Why visit Costa Rica: a small, peaceful country packed with rainforest, volcanoes, wildlife and two coastlines, with some of the finest eco-lodges in the Americas.



Where the forest runs out of land

NEARLY 6%
of the world's species

25%+
of the land protected

900+
species of bird

1948
the year it abolished its army

2
oceans, about 40 minutes apart by small plane

A big address book

Rainforest, cloud forest, dry forest and mangrove, all within a day's drive, and every one of them occupied.

Green on purpose

The country spent its army money on schools and national parks, and it shows: trails, rangers and naturalists who know every tree.

Two oceans before lunch

Breakfast with toucans on the Caribbean side, lunch on a Pacific beach. Very few countries can promise that, and fewer can keep it.

LINGER LONGER *"Costa Rica is small enough to cross in a day and big enough to keep surprising you for thirty-five years." — J. W.*

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Dry, green, and everything in between

The best time to visit Costa Rica is December to April for sunshine, or July to October for turtles, whales and fewer people. Here is where I'd be, month by month.

January
MONTEVERDE · CLOUD FOREST

Quetzal season begins. The bird is real; your guide knows which tree.

February
CARIBBEAN COAST

The Caribbean side dries out. Reef, reggae and nobody on the beach.

March
GUANACASTE

The sunniest month in the northwest. Pack sunscreen like you mean it.

April
ARENAL

Last of the dry season. Easter week is busy: book early or go late.

May
PACUARE · TURRIALBA

First rains, first green. The forest exhales.

June
PACUARE RIVER

The rivers rise and the rafting gets lively. Hold on.

July
PACIFIC COAST · TORTUGUERO

The "little summer" on the Pacific, and green turtles begin nesting.

August
UVITA · OSA

Humpbacks offshore in the morning, waterfalls in the afternoon.

September
CARIBBEAN COAST

The Pacific gets soaked; the Caribbean smiles. Go east.

October
TORTUGUERO

Turtle hatchlings sprint for the sea. The quietest month, and the best-kept secret.

November
OSA PENINSULA

Shoulder season: fewer people, fair weather, good rates.

December
EVERYWHERE

Dry season returns, and so does everyone. We booked your room in June.

DECEMBER – APRIL · THE DRY SEASON

Blue skies on the Pacific side and the easiest roads. Also the busiest months, so book the good lodges early.

MAY – NOVEMBER · THE GREEN SEASON

Sunny mornings, afternoon downpours, roaring waterfalls and fewer people. My favourite time, and the forest agrees.

Guidance only; nature keeps her own calendar. Wildlife months confirmed with our naturalists each season.

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Find your Costa Rica

The best months and places in Costa Rica by type of traveler: first-timers, families, honeymooners, wildlife lovers, wellness seekers and more.

BEST FOR
Families, wildlife lovers, couples and anyone who likes a little mud with their luxury

IDEAL LENGTH
10 to 14 days: two coasts and the volcano

HOW
Lodges and villas, linked by small plane and private driver

First-timers

BEST · DEC–APR

WHERE · ARENAL · MONTEVERDE · GUANACASTE

OUR PICK · TWO OCEANS, ONE VOLCANO

"Volcano, cloud forest, beach, in that order. Dessert last."

Families, young kids

BEST · DEC–APR · JULY

WHERE · ARENAL · PAPAGAYO

OUR PICK · FOUR SEASONS PAPAGAYO

"Sloths before breakfast, frogs at bedtime, and nobody asks for a screen."

Teens & three generations

BEST · JUN–AUG · DEC

WHERE · PACUARE · ARENAL · THE OSA

OUR PICK · PACUARE LODGE

"Raft in, and suddenly Grandpa is the coolest person on the trip."

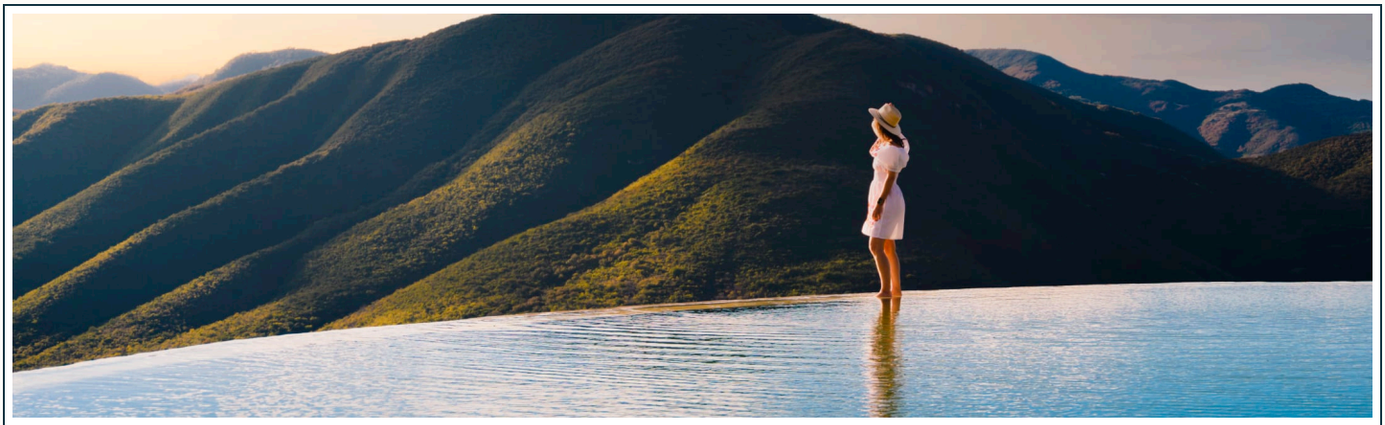
Honeymooners

BEST · DEC–APR

WHERE · RINCÓN DE LA VIEJA · THE OSA

OUR PICK · ORIGINS LODGE

"Seven rooms, one hot tub, zero reasons to come down for breakfast."



Wellness seekers, this way

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Wildlife lovers & birders

BEST · DEC–APR BIRDS · JUL–OCT TURTLES & WHALES

WHERE · THE OSA · TORTUGUERO · MONTEVERDE

OUR PICK · LAPA RIOS

"Bring binoculars and an extra memory card. Then another."

Wellness seekers

BEST · MAY–NOV

WHERE · NOSARA · ARENAL

OUR PICK · NAYARA SPRINGS · HARMONY

"Green season, green juice, nobody you know."

Short on time

BEST · ANY DRY MONTH

WHERE · ARENAL AND ONE BEACH

OUR PICK · TWO BASES, ONE FLIGHT

"Seven days is a trailer. Make it a good one."

Curious surfers

BEST · APR–OCT, PACIFIC

WHERE · TURN TO PAGE 20

OUR PICK · JAMES'S SURF GUIDE

"You know who you are. Start at the back."

THINK TWICE IF YOU'RE…

Anyone in a hurry
The map says two hours. The road says four. Costa Rica agrees with the road.
INSTEAD · FLY BETWEEN REGIONS; STAY LONGER IN FEWER

Perfect-weather people
It's a rainforest. It rains. That's the deal.
INSTEAD · DECEMBER TO APRIL, PACIFIC SIDE

Big-city nightlife
The night shift here is frogs and fireflies.
INSTEAD · TWO NIGHTS IN SAN JOSÉ, THEN OUT

Limited mobility
Muddy trails, river landings, boat transfers.
INSTEAD · PAPAGAYO AND GENTLER LODGES; TELL US AND WE'LL PLAN IT

Bug-phobic
Something will crawl past. It's probably harmless. Probably.
INSTEAD · DRY-SEASON GUANACASTE, SCREENED SUITES



Three generations, one terrace

Minimum ages for rafting, ziplines and some lodges apply `[confirm per property]`. Not sure where you fit? That's what the call is for.

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Who you'll meet

Where and when to see sloths, scarlet macaws, quetzals, tree frogs, whales and sea turtles in Costa Rica.

Sloths, two- and three-toed

WHERE · EVERYWHERE WITH TREES · BEST · ALL YEAR

Slower than the queue at Customs, and braver: once a week they climb all the way down for a bathroom break.

Scarlet macaws

WHERE · THE OSA · CARARA · BEST · ALL YEAR

You'll hear them first. Two macaws arguing sound exactly like a long marriage.

Resplendent quetzal

WHERE · MONTEVERDE · SAN GERARDO DE DOTA · BEST · DEC–APR [CONFIRM]

The bird the Maya held sacred. Worth the 5 a.m. start, and the wet socks.

Red-eyed tree frog

WHERE · LOWLAND RAINFOREST, AT NIGHT · BEST · ALL YEAR

The country's unofficial mascot. Night walks only: he does not do mornings.

Humpback whales

WHERE · MARINO BALLENA · UVITA · THE OSA · BEST · JUL–OCT · DEC–MAR

Two populations, two seasons. Our captains know when to switch the engine off.

Sea turtles

WHERE · TORTUGUERO · OSTIONAL · BEST · JUL–OCT

Red light only, voices down, and let the turtle go first.

Keel-billed toucan

WHERE · CARIBBEAN AND NORTHERN LOWLANDS · BEST · ALL YEAR

A banana with wings. Looks top-heavy, flies anyway.

Baird's tapir

WHERE · CORCOVADO · BEST · ALL YEAR

Half pig, half elephant, all shy. If you see one, buy your guide dinner.



He does not do mornings



Humpbacks, twice a year

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...and who to give space

The Costa Rica wildlife to respect: snakes, crocodiles, ants and the occasional thief. All of them were here first.

Terciopelo (fer-de-lance)
Venomous, shy and not forgiving. Stay on the trail, wear closed shoes, walk with a guide after dark.

American crocodiles
They like river mouths as much as you do. Admire from the Tárcoles bridge (don't-miss no. 5); swim elsewhere.

Bullet ants
Inch-long and named for how the sting feels. Watch where you put your hands.

Hornets and wasps
My old friends from 1991. Check the rafters before you sit. Then sit.

Mosquitoes
Small, persistent and occasionally carrying dengue. Repellent at dusk, long sleeves after dark.

White-faced capuchins
Clever, cute and criminal. They will take your lunch, your sunglasses and, given time, your passport.

Howler monkeys
The loudest land animal in the Americas, every morning at 4.30. Don't stand directly underneath. Trust me.

Coatis
The raccoon's organised cousin. Travels in gangs, opens bags. Zip everything.

Rip currents
Not an animal, but they bite. Swim at lifeguarded beaches and ask before you paddle out.

HOW TO SEE MORE · FOUR HOUSE RULES

01 · EARLY
Dawn and dusk are rush hour. Midday is for the lodge pool.

02 · A GUIDE
A good naturalist spots a sloth from a moving car. You won't. Yet.

03 · LOOK UP
If three people are staring at a tree, stop. Something is in it.

04 · HANDS OFF
Never feed anything, especially the capuchins. They talk.

Nearly six percent of the world's species live here. You won't see them all. Come back; I'm still trying.
— J. Wild

Sightings are never guaranteed, which is exactly why they're thrilling. Seasons are guidance; your naturalist has the final word.

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The map I'd draw you on a napkin

Ten places in Costa Rica I'd never let you skip, numbered on the map with a brass marker.



Contours and relief are decorative. ▲ volcanoes and the highest peak, Chirripó. Positions approximate.

1 Tortuguero canals · CARIBBEAN COAST
No roads, all canals. Turtles nest July to October; caimans work the day shift.

2 Arenal's hot river · LA FORTUNA
A volcano-warmed river where the locals soak for free. Nature's jacuzzi, no booking required.

3 Río Celeste · TENORIO VOLCANO NATIONAL PARK
Where two rivers meet and turn sky-blue. It looks retouched. It isn't.

4 Monteverde hanging bridges · CLOUD FOREST
Walk the canopy at cloud level. Go early; the quetzals don't do crowds.

5 Tárcoles River bridge · CENTRAL PACIFIC
Dozens of crocodiles posing below. The best free photo op that can also eat you.

6 Corcovado, Sirena station · THE OSA PENINSULA
The wildest walk in Central America. Tapirs, macaws and mud to the knee.

7 The whale's tail · MARINO BALLENA, UVITA
At low tide the sandbar draws a whale's tail. The real ones swim past in season.

8 Ostional arribadas · NICOYA PENINSULA
On arribada nights, thousands of olive ridley turtles come ashore together. Nature's flash mob.

9 Tarrazú coffee farms · LOS SANTOS HIGHLANDS
The best cup of your life, poured by the person who picked it.

10 Rincón de la Vieja · GUANACASTE
Bubbling mud pots and steaming vents. The volcano smells faintly of breakfast eggs.

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What Costa Rica will show you, if you let it

Small moments that make a Costa Rica trip: the ones no itinerary lists and every traveler remembers.

AROUND THE CORNER OF ANY TRAIL

...a leaf-cutter ant highway, carrying the forest across your path one leaf at a time. Step over, never on.

AROUND THE CORNER AT NIGHT

...a glass frog. You can see its heart beating through its belly. Bring a headlamp and a sense of wonder.

AROUND THE CORNER OF EVERY LODGE

...a blue morpho butterfly, flashing electric blue like a camera going off in the forest.

AROUND 2 P.M. IN THE GREEN SEASON

...the downpour. Set your watch by it, then order another coffee.

AROUND 5.30 A.M.

...the dawn chorus: toucans, parrots and motmots, all talking at once. Nobody sleeps in. Nobody minds.

AROUND HALF PAST FIVE, ALL YEAR

...sunset. This close to the equator, the sun keeps office hours.

AROUND THE CORNER FROM THE MAIN ROAD

...a soda, a family kitchen with a casado better than most lodge dinners. Point, smile, eat.

AROUND BREAKFAST

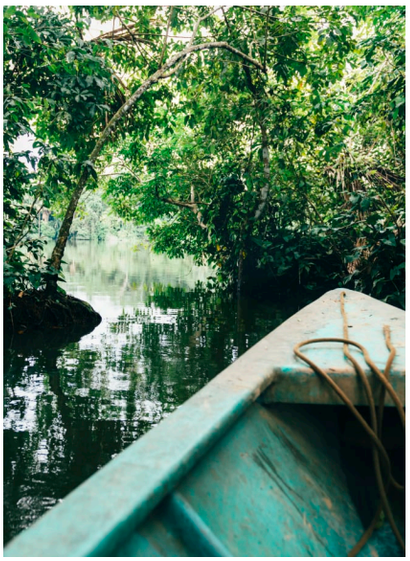
...gallo pinto, rice and beans, every single morning. By day three you'll ask for it at home.

AROUND THE CORNER OF A MOUNTAIN ROAD

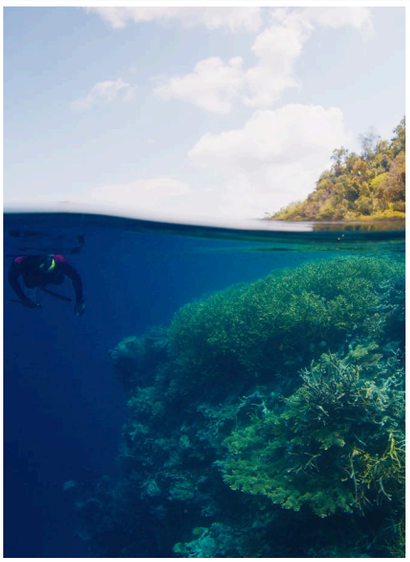
...a fruit stand. Mango with lime and salt. You're welcome.

AROUND THE LAST CORNER

...a Tico who answers every question, good news or bad, with "pura vida". By day three, so will you.



Round the bend, something is watching



Two worlds, one waterline

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7 DAYS · ARENAL & ONE BEACH

You miss: the Osa, and the other ocean.

10 DAYS · VOLCANO, CLOUD & WILD

You miss: the Caribbean and its turtles.

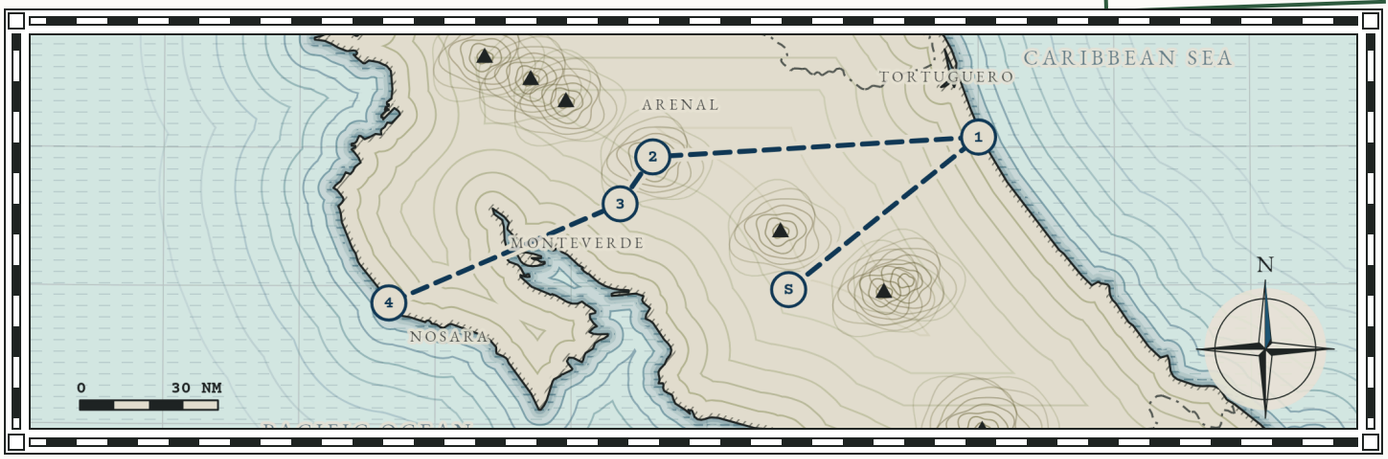
12+ DAYS · TWO OCEANS, ONE VOLCANO

You miss: nothing but the office.

Two Oceans, One Volcano

JW-CR-C01 · 12 DAYS · TORTUGUERO · ARENAL · MONTEVERDE · NOSARA

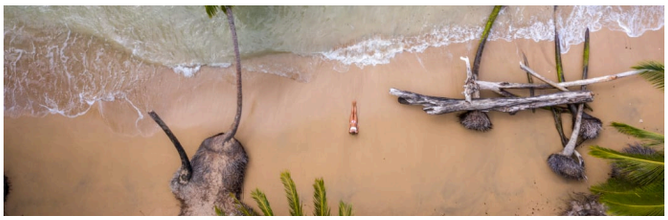
I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991



S San José · 1 Tortuguero · 2 Arenal · 3 Monteverde · 4 Nosara. Small plane to the Caribbean, private driver for the rest.



The Caribbean side, slower still



Nosara, roughly

Days 1–3	**Tortuguero.** Fly in over the canals. Turtles on the beach at night in season.
Days 4–6	**Arenal.** Hot springs, hanging bridges and the volcano at dawn, clouds allowing.
Days 7–8	**Monteverde.** Into the cloud forest at first light.
Days 9–11	**Nosara.** Beach, yoga, a sea kayak, nowhere to be.
Day 12	**Home.** Out through Liberia.

WHO IT SUITS

First-timers, families, and anyone who wants the whole country without the long drives.

FROM

$[____] pp · 11 nights

OFFER · TR-CRC-JW-F-0001 · SEE PAGE 17

QR

Scan for the live route map.

LINGER LONGER *"Go to Tortuguero first. After a day on the canals, nothing else on the trip will feel like traffic." — J. W.*

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Volcano, Cloud & Wild

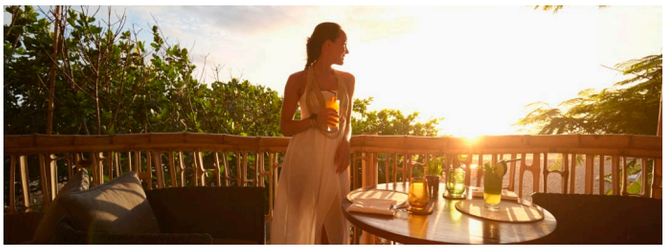
JW-CR-W01 · 10 DAYS · SAN JOSÉ · PACUARE · ARENAL · OSA · SMALL PLANES

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit

A ten-day Costa Rica rainforest itinerary: whitewater rafting, Arenal volcano and the Osa Peninsula, linked by small plane.



S San José · 1 Pacuare River · 2 Arenal · 3 Osa Peninsula. One raft, two small planes, no wrong turns.



Sundowners above the canopy



Cloud-forest detail

Day 1	**San José.** Land, sleep, eat well.
Days 2–3	**Pacuare.** Raft in to the lodge. There is no road, which is the point.
Days 4–6	**Arenal.** Hot springs, hanging bridges, the volcano at dawn.
Days 7–9	**The Osa.** Corcovado on foot, the Pacific by boat, whales in season.
Day 10	**Home.** Small plane to San José, connect out.

WHO IT SUITS

Families with kids eight and up, wildlife lovers and the active.

FROM

$[_____] pp · 9 nights

OFFER · WAN-CRW-JW-F-0001 · SEE PAGE 17

QR

Scan for the live route map.

LINGER LONGER *"Pack one more pair of dry socks than you think you need. Then one more." — J. W.*

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The Contrast

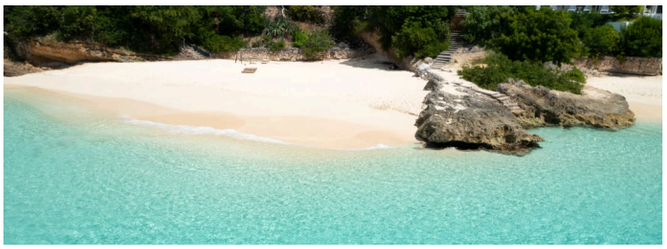
JW-CON-C01 · 4 NIGHTS PAPAGAYO, THEN 4 NIGHTS IN THE OSA · 9 DAYS

I KEEP GOING BACK
the James Wild way

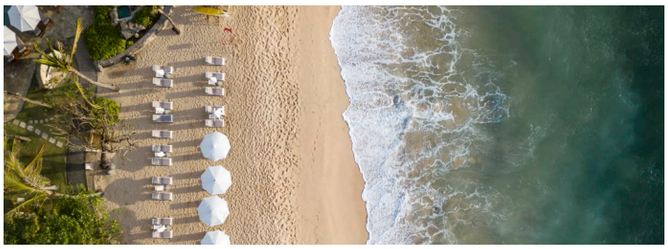
A nine-day Costa Rica honeymoon or couples itinerary: a Guanacaste beach resort, then a rainforest lodge on the Osa Peninsula.



Papagayo, four nights · then one small-plane hop south to the Osa Peninsula



Polish first



Papagayo, at ease

Days 1–4	**Papagayo.** Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo. Calm bays, long dinners, a day on the water.
Day 5	**Fly south.** Over the Nicoya and down the coast to Puerto Jiménez.
Days 5–8	**The Osa.** Lapa Rios: rainforest at the door, the Pacific below.
Day 9	**Home.** Back via San José or Liberia.

WHO IT SUITS

Couples, honeymooners, and anyone who wants polish first and mud second.

FROM

$[_____] pp · 8 nights

OFFER · CON-CR-JW-F-0001 · SEE PAGE 17

QR

Scan for the live route map.

LINGER LONGER *"Good journeys have seams. Polish, then mud. You should feel the change." — J. W.*

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Small planes, big rivers

How to get around Costa Rica: domestic flights between regions, a private driver for short legs, and boats and rafts where the road gives up.

PHOTO TO LICENSE · GETTY 1695657254

Small planes

DOMESTIC FLIGHTS · 20–60 MINUTES

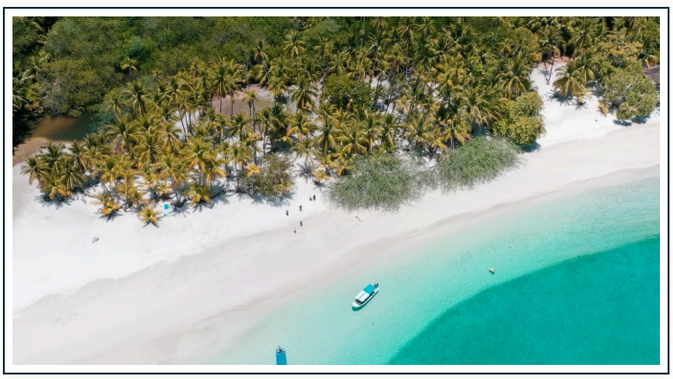
Two domestic airlines, SANSA and Costa Rica Green Airways, link San José to the coasts: Nosara, Tambor, Tamarindo, Quepos, Golfito, Puerto Jiménez, Drake Bay and Tortuguero. Some strips are paved now. Some are not. The cows have mostly moved on.

PHOTO TO LICENSE · GETTY 1297975323

A 4x4, with a driver

PRIVATE TRANSFERS · RIVER FORDS INCLUDED

A good driver knows which rivers to cross and which to admire from the bank. I learned the hard way, so you can learn the easy way.



Boats

TORTUGUERO CANALS · THE OSA · GOLFO DULCE

Some of the best of Costa Rica has no road at all. Tortuguero is reached by canal; parts of the Osa by small boat from Puerto Jiménez.



Rafts

PACUARE RIVER · CLASS III–IV

The only way into Pacuare Lodge is down the river. Your bags go by road; you go by raft. Nobody has ever asked to swap.

In 1991 the runway check was simple: one low pass to move the cows, one to make sure they stayed moved. These days there's a windsock and, usually, no cows.
— J. Wild

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Seven stays, coast to cloud forest

The best luxury lodges and resorts in Costa Rica, from Arenal hot springs to the Osa rainforest and the Guanacaste coast.



1 Nayara Springs · 2 Lapa Rios Lodge · 3 Pacuare Lodge · 4 Origins Lodge · 5 Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo · 6 Hacienda AltaGracia · 7 Harmony Hotel Nosara

> *One night in a jungle lodge is worth three in a city hotel. Choose two bases, not five.*
> — *J. Wild*

Room counts and facilities from the properties' published listings; confirm with each property. Partner photography to follow.

1 Nayara Springs

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

ARENAL · LA FORTUNA

Thirty-five adults-only villas facing the volcano, each with a private plunge pool fed by mineral hot springs.

Best for: Couples and anyone who likes a hot soak with a view.

2 Lapa Rios Lodge

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

OSA PENINSULA · CABO MATAPALO

Seventeen bungalows on a private rainforest reserve where the Golfo Dulce meets the Pacific. Whales from the veranda in season.

Best for: Wildlife lovers and the properly curious.

3 Pacuare Lodge

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

PACUARE RIVER

Twenty suites and villas in the forest, reached by whitewater raft. The Canopy Suite has its own suspension bridge.

Best for: Families with teens and adventurous couples.

4 Origins Lodge

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

RINCÓN DE LA VIEJA · TENORIO

Seven rooms and villas with views to the volcanoes and Lake Nicaragua, and wood-fired hot tubs of their own.

Best for: Honeymooners and anyone hiding from the world.

5 Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

GUANACASTE · PAPAGAYO

182 rooms, suites and villas on a forested peninsula between two beaches, newly renovated with plunge-pool canopy suites.

Best for: Families, three generations and surf by boat.

6 Hacienda AltaGracia

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

PÉREZ ZELEDÓN · TALAMANCA

Fifty casitas on a coffee and horse estate in the southern mountains, from Auberge Resorts.

Best for: Riders, coffee lovers and a quiet reset.

7 Harmony Hotel Nosara

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

NOSARA · PLAYA GUIONES

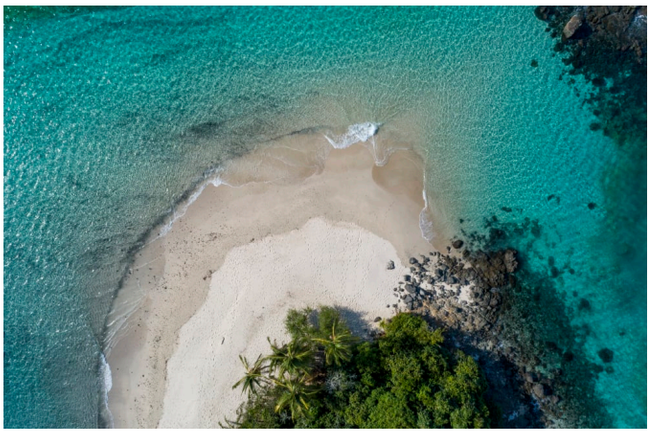
Twenty-four rooms and two villas a short walk through the trees to Guiones, with an open-air yoga pavilion.

Best for: Surfers, yogis and slow mornings.

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Slower is the whole point

Our Costa Rica offers reward staying longer, not booking sooner. Every code is tied to your Folio.



Worth another night

Most Costa Rica regrets are about driving, not money. People try to see six regions in eight days and spend most of it behind a truck full of pineapples. We'd rather you stayed.

Three nights or don't unpack. The first day you hear everything. The third day you stop noticing. That's when you've arrived.
— J. Wild

TIME REWARDED

Two Oceans, One Volcano

Twelve days or more, coast to coast: `[__]` off the second week.

TR-CRC-JW-F-0001

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night in the Osa

On Volcano, Cloud & Wild: `[offer to confirm with the property]`

WAN-CRW-JW-F-0001

THE CONTRAST RATE

Papagayo, then the Osa

Both stays priced together: `[__]`.

CON-CR-JW-F-0001

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Rules of the road

Practical Costa Rica travel tips from thirty-five years of getting it wrong first.

01 **Fly the far ones.** A forty-minute flight beats a nine-hour drive, every time.

02 **Never drive after dark.** Unlit roads, surprise potholes and the occasional cow. Daylight only.

03 **Two nights minimum anywhere you fly to.** Otherwise you're just commuting with a better view.

04 **Respect the one-lane bridges.** The side with the "Ceda el paso" sign waits. Wave either way.

05 **Book the dry season early.** The best lodges fill months ahead for December to April.

06 **Carry small colones.** For the family kitchens and the fruit stands. Lodges take cards.

Words we've struck out

The travel clichés we refuse to print, and why.

~~UNDISCOVERED~~ — The surfers found it in the sixties. The Ticos found it long before that.

~~OFF THE BEATEN PATH~~ — In 1991, there was no path. Now there's a very good one, and we'll take you past the end of it.

~~PARADISE~~ — Paradise has fewer mosquitoes. Costa Rica has more fun.

~~HIDDEN GEM~~ — If it were hidden, we couldn't book it. It's just quiet.

Every rule on this page cost me something to learn. You get them for free. That's the deal.
— J. Wild

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LAST CHECKED
October 2026

What to know, and what not to expect

Costa Rica entry requirements, money, packing and the honest answers to the questions everyone asks.

Getting there

Two international airports: Juan Santamaría (SJO) near San José, and Daniel Oduber (LIR) at Liberia for Guanacaste and the Nicoya. Arrive in daylight if you can.

At the border

US citizens need a passport valid for the length of the stay and proof of onward travel; stays of up to 180 days without a visa are allowed at the officer's discretion. The $29 departure tax is usually included in the airfare [confirm per airline].

Money

US dollars are accepted almost everywhere; colones are handy for small places. Cards work at lodges and most restaurants.

Pack

Reef-safe sunscreen, a light rain jacket, quick-dry everything, closed shoes for muddy trails, binoculars, a headlamp for night walks, and soft bags for small planes.

What not to expect

~~STREET ADDRESSES~~	Directions come from landmarks: "two hundred metres north of the old fig tree."
~~ON-TIME ARRIVALS~~	Roads, rivers and rain run their own schedule. We build in a buffer.
~~FAST WI-FI IN THE FOREST~~	Limited at some lodges [confirm]. Consider it a feature.
~~CROWDED TRAILS~~	Not at dawn, and not where we send you.

Straight answers

Will I see a sloth? Almost certainly. Getting one to look at you is another matter.

Can I drive myself? You can. I did, for years. Hire a driver.

Is it safe? As anywhere: lock the car, don't leave bags on the beach, and listen to the lifeguards.

Children? A great fit. Ages for rafting and ziplines [confirm per operator].

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I KEEP GOING BACK
mapped 1990s

If you came to surf

The best surf spots in Costa Rica, plus Nicaragua and Panama, from the surf pioneer who mapped them in the early 1990s.



Positions approximate. Surf with a local guide and respect the line-up; some breaks are reached only by boat or across private land.

01 Popoyo · NICARAGUA · RIVAS
Reef, point and beach peaks with near-constant offshore winds off Lake Nicaragua. The outer reef is for experts.

02 Witch's Rock · SANTA ROSA NATIONAL PARK
Roca Bruja: a rock and rivermouth wave that can barrel, about 45 minutes by permitted boat from Playas del Coco.

03 Ollie's Point · SANTA ROSA NATIONAL PARK
A long right-hand point, best low to mid tide. Boat only, park fee paid.

04 Playa Negra · NEAR TAMARINDO
A reef right that tubes at low to mid tide. Get there before the wind does.

05 Nosara · Playa Guiones · NICOYA PENINSULA
Peeling sand-bottom peaks with a friendly inside. The best place in the country to learn.

06 Santa Teresa · Mal País · NICOYA PENINSULA
Rock-ledge rights and lefts that barrel on the right tide; left points at the south end.

07 Playa Hermosa · NEAR JACÓ
A powerful multi-peak beach break that fires in August.

08 Dominical · SOUTH PACIFIC
Punchy beach break below the jungle, with whales offshore in season.

09 Pavones · GOLFO DULCE
One of the longest lefts in the world, rides up to about a kilometre on a south-southwest swell.

10 Salsa Brava · PUERTO VIEJO · CARIBBEAN
A hollow right over shallow reef, the country's heaviest wave. November to March, experts only.

11 Bocas del Toro · PANAMA · CARIBBEAN
Reef breaks at Paunch, Bluff, Carenero and Silverbacks, best in the northern winter.

12 Santa Catalina · PANAMA · VERAGUAS
La Punta, a rocky point that breaks left and right and gets big. March to October.

TIDES RULE
Most reef and point breaks here work on a particular tide. We plan the days around them, not the other way round.

BOATS & PARKS
Ollie's Point and Witch's Rock sit inside Santa Rosa National Park: permitted boats and park fees only.

BOARDS
Small planes have strict baggage limits. We arrange quality rentals so you travel light.

THE LONG WAY ROUND
Ask for our 14-day surf run, Liberia to Pavones, the coast I mapped.

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Words you'll hear on the road

Pura vida
Pure life. Hello, goodbye, thank you, no worries, and the national philosophy.

Tico, Tica
A Costa Rican. Named, so the story goes, for a fondness for the diminutive "-tico".

Casado
The plate of the day: rice, beans, salad, plantain and something good. "Married", because it all goes together.

Gallo pinto
Rice and beans, the breakfast of the nation.

Green season
The polite name for the rainy season, May to November.

Veranillo
The "little summer", a drier spell on the Pacific side around July.

Tico time
Like regular time, but relaxed. Plan for it and you'll love it.

Mae
Mate, dude, buddy. You'll hear it a hundred times a day.

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COLOPHON
Set in Bodoni Moda, Libre Caslon Display and Text and Courier Prime, with James's signature in Mrs Saint Delafield. Maps engraved in the James Wild & Co. house style; colours drawn from Costa Rica's terrain. Designed and ledgered by James Wild & Co., Miami. Field Guide No. 03, Edition 2027.

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YOUR FIELD NOTES

Write it down before you forget

For the frog you saw, the road you shouldn't have taken, and the name of that family kitchen with the perfect casado.

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YOUR TRAVELER FOLIO · JW-F-0001

Your journey, in your hand

Circle your month and your kind of traveler, snap a photo of this page and text it to James. He'll call you with a plan.

My month	☐ Dec–Apr ☐ May–Jun ☐ Jul–Aug ☐ Sep–Nov
I'm traveling as	☐ First-timer ☐ Family ☐ Couple ☐ Wildlife lover ☐ Wellness
Coast, forest or both	☐ Pacific ☐ Caribbean ☐ Rainforest ☐ All of it
Don't-miss numbers I circled	
Something to celebrate	

QR

TEXT YOUR FOLIO TO JAMES · 561.479.6355

Or scan to book a call: jameswildco.com/costa-rica?src=fg03

A LAST WORD FROM JAMES

Jane, that's Costa Rica as I've known it since 1991, from a stalled car in a river to a hot spring under a volcano. Circle what moves you, cross out what doesn't, and send it back to me. I've already taken every wrong turn in the country. You don't have to.

Til our next expedition,

James

JAMES PAPAGNO · CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER

JAMES WILD & CO.

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HISTORY Adventure Expeditions and the breaks mapped in the early 1990s: from James Papagno's own recollection.
SOURCES Arrivals: ICT figures via Wikipedia (1991) and La Nación (2025). Biodiversity and protected areas: Embassy of Costa Rica; SINAC. Army abolished 1948: Constitution of Costa Rica, Art. 12. Seasons and surf: The Surf Atlas, CR Surf, Surfer Today, Tourism Panama; turtles: ACTO/SINAC. Entry: US Department of State. Domestic airlines: SANSA; La Nación. Stays: Forbes Travel Guide, Black Tomato, i-escape, Four Seasons, Virtuoso, Timbuktu, Costa Rica Experts; confirm with each property before booking.
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JAMES WILD & CO.

Recorded from experience. Exploring Since 1982.

Til our next expedition

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COMPLIMENTARY FIELD GUIDE NO. 03
COSTA RICA · THE LONG WAY ROUND
EDITION 2027

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